CHAPTER V

The Grammar of Unsaid Things

Kolkata · August 2023

“What was ordinary to one became extraordinary to the other, and neither had reason to speak of it. There were no promises in those moments, no meanings deliberately concealed, only the quiet ease of two people growing familiar with each other. Yet sometimes, without either person knowing, the smallest things begin to occupy the largest places in a life.”

August did not announce itself as a turning point.

The rains continued over Kolkata, sometimes arriving in earnest and sometimes merely threatening to. The roads outside the coaching centre remained crowded, the classrooms remained much as they had been, and the teachers continued their determined efforts to make an unreasonable amount of information fit inside a reasonable number of hours.

Utkarsh had spent much of the previous month learning how to sit beside Sanondita without appearing excessively conscious of the fact. By August, he had become reasonably accomplished at it. He no longer rehearsed an entire conversation before asking her a question, nor did he regard every silence as evidence that he had said something wrong.

There were still occasional difficulties. He could speak quite comfortably about a question from class, a teacher’s peculiar habits, or some unfortunate incident involving another student. But the moment he considered saying something that might reveal how much he enjoyed speaking to her, his vocabulary became considerably less dependable.

Fortunately, ordinary friendship seldom asked him to explain itself.

They began talking more often. Lessons supplied some of the material, though not necessarily the most memorable part. A teacher's mannerisms could provide almost as much for discussion as the subject being taught, and the behaviour of their fellow students was occasionally more difficult to understand than anything written on the board.

Neither was entirely innocent in these observations. Sanondita had a way of noticing things Utkarsh might otherwise have missed: a particular expression, an unnecessary flourish in an explanation, the solemn confidence with which an obviously doubtful answer had been delivered. A few words from her, and he would have to make an immediate and rather unsuccessful effort to preserve his composure.

He contributed his share. Sometimes he said something under his breath and saw her lower her head towards her notebook, her shoulders moving as she tried not to laugh. He learned to recognise the warning signs. Once she began avoiding his eyes, looking at her would make matters worse. Knowing this did not always prevent him from looking.

They sat in the front row, a location that offered certain academic advantages and very few opportunities for misconduct. A teacher did not have to turn around to investigate a disturbance already seated directly in front of him. Utkarsh occasionally wondered whether they would behave more sensibly farther back. He doubted it; they would merely be less visible.

Some conversations lasted only a few seconds before the teacher resumed speaking or one of them remembered the examination they were preparing for. Others continued between lessons, picking up where they had stopped. Sanondita might turn towards him to ask something, share an observation, or finish a story. He no longer needed a new reason each time he wanted to speak.

Diya had become increasingly irregular in her attendance. There were days when she did not appear at all. Utkarsh never asked why. He could have; it was a perfectly ordinary question. But asking would draw attention to something he preferred to accept without discussion.

He hoped Diya was well. He was also, regrettably, pleased with the seating arrangement. The two sentiments coexisted without much difficulty, although he suspected they would sound less respectable if expressed aloud.

Over time, the place beside Sanondita ceased to feel like a seat he had been fortunate enough to obtain. He arrived expecting to sit there, open his notebook, and find her within speaking distance. He still kept his arm within his own desk and made room when she reached for something. These small adjustments no longer occupied half his attention. He could move his notebook and carry on speaking in the same moment.

Outside the classroom, something similar was happening. Their WhatsApp conversations gradually wandered beyond the examinations and schedules that had first made them possible. A question about the following day might become a complaint about a teacher, then something neither would have thought to begin a conversation about. Sometimes she asked first; sometimes he did.

He still read certain replies more than once. Old habits did not disappear merely because circumstances had improved. He could begin typing, decide he sounded too eager, remove a word, put it back, and eventually send a sentence that looked as though it had required no effort at all. He was becoming remarkably skilled at making unnecessary labour invisible.

Sanondita could ask a question without apparently considering how long he might spend thinking about it afterward. He liked that ease. He wanted her to be able to laugh at something foolish he said and return to her work. He also wanted her to know him well enough that he would not have to be interesting every time he opened his mouth.

Whether he was succeeding was difficult to measure. There were no marks awarded for becoming someone's friend, no published list of successful candidates. He would have preferred a slightly more transparent system. Instead, there were unfinished conversations, jokes she remembered, and the occasional pleasure of finding that she had already turned towards him when he was about to speak.

One afternoon, after an exchange that left them both struggling to pay attention, Sanondita turned back towards the board. Utkarsh did the same. For several minutes, they listened without speaking. Pages turned; outside, traffic carried on with its usual impatience. He copied the next line without looking at her again.

He was beginning to learn that happiness did not always demand his full attention. Sometimes it could remain beside him while he worked, waiting quietly for the next opportunity to laugh.

Bikash Sir had arrived at the coaching centre towards the end of July, bringing an enthusiasm that seemed to have been issued in quantities considerably greater than the classroom required. He was young, energetic, and determined not to let English grammar become a solemn affair. Even the driest rule received an explanation that suggested its importance extended well beyond the examination.

Utkarsh liked him. His teaching was useful, and there was something reassuring about a person who could approach familiar material as though it still deserved his full attention. Sanondita appeared less enthusiastic. Utkarsh could not have said precisely why. Perhaps she disliked the style, perhaps she preferred studying English on her own, or perhaps the reason simply had not come up between them. She had begun skipping the second class whenever Bikash Sir was scheduled to teach.

At first, Utkarsh continued attending. He had come to Kolkata to prepare for a competitive examination. English was part of it. A teacher had been appointed to teach it. The arrangement was straightforward enough; for most of his life, he would have regarded attendance as a question requiring very little reflection.

His circumstances had become more complicated than the timetable suggested.

When Sanondita left after the first class, he took out his English notebook, uncapped his pen, and tried to follow the lesson. Sometimes he succeeded. At other times, he wondered whether she had reached home, or whether she was spending the hour doing something considerably more pleasant than correcting sentences written by people who appeared incapable of speaking their own language. Then Bikash Sir would ask a question, and Utkarsh would discover how long his attention had been elsewhere.

There was no reason for his academic decisions to depend on whether she happened to be beside him. He reminded himself of this frequently. The frequency was not encouraging.

He also did not want Sanondita to think he attended merely because she did. Enjoying her company was one thing. Organising his education around her attendance was an admission he did not care to make. He developed a policy: he would attend English whether she attended or not. It was sensible, supported by sound academic reasoning and a respectable degree of personal pride. For the first few weeks, he followed it.

Sometimes she gathered her things after the first lesson while he remained seated. He would ask whether she was leaving, although her packed bag had provided a fairly persuasive answer. She would say yes. He would wish her goodbye and open his English notebook.

Then he would hope she noticed that he stayed.

This was the least impressive part of the policy. He had adopted it to establish that his choices were independent of her and now wanted her to recognise his independence. He could not have explained what he expected her to do with the information. Still, when she left, he remained.

There were afternoons when Bikash Sir’s class genuinely absorbed him. The teacher could be unexpectedly entertaining, particularly when an example failed to produce the response he

wanted and he refused to abandon it until someone understood. Utkarsh sometimes forgot the empty chair for several minutes at a time. He would be writing down a useful explanation, or smiling at something the teacher had said, before he remembered whom he would have liked to share it with.

One evening, while they were discussing the following day's classes, he typed a reply less neutral than his usual ones.

Yes, but only if you go.

He read it and hesitated. Friends said such things. He had heard people make considerably more suggestive remarks without visible consequences. Yet the words looked different beneath Sanondita's name. There was still time to replace them with a simple yes, or mention the timetable, or produce any of the practical sentences at which he had become so accomplished.

He sent it.

For a few seconds, he was pleased with himself. Then he wondered whether it sounded too familiar. Perhaps she would take it as a joke. Perhaps she would wait for him to supply the part that made it funny. The possibility that she might not reply at all occurred to him with an urgency he knew it did not deserve.

He put down the phone, then picked it up again. Nothing in the message had changed. He checked anyway, as though the words might have rearranged themselves into something more embarrassing during his absence.

He had asked for her number, sat beside her in class, and learned to speak to her with increasing ease. Six ordinary words could apparently undo his confidence in all three achievements.

When they next met, they spoke as usual. There was no awkward reckoning, no sign that the message required an explanation. He was relieved. He was also a little disappointed that something which had taken so much courage could pass so easily into the ordinary course of her day.

Later, he tried to decide what he had wanted her to notice. Certainly not everything. He was not ready for that. Only that her

company mattered, perhaps, without having to account for how much. He wanted to be understood at precisely the point where he stopped being willing to explain himself.

The following evening, he found himself hoping she might ask whether he was coming. He knew what he would say if she did. He waited a little longer before putting the phone away.

There was a peculiar disadvantage to becoming familiar with someone: the more naturally they spoke to you, the less time you had to prepare for what they might say. In July, Utkarsh had approached Sanondita with questions he already knew the answers to, invented difficulties, and asked for her phone number without remembering to introduce himself. By August, their conversations could begin without the slightest ceremony. He enjoyed the change immensely. He was still learning what to do with it.

On the evening of 10 August, Sanondita asked whether he would attend coaching the following day. He replied that he intended to. Then another message appeared.

Come tomorrow. I don't want to attend the classes alone.

He read it again. She wanted someone familiar beside her. Diya had been attending irregularly; he was a friend whose company she apparently enjoyed. He understood this perfectly and would have liked, for a moment, to understand it less thoroughly.

He had spent months arranging small hopes around the possibility of seeing her. There had been mornings when the thought of finding her in the classroom made the journey seem shorter, and conversations that followed him home long after their subject had become difficult to remember. He had never told her any of that. Now she was asking him to come.

Because she doesn't want to sit alone, he reminded himself.

But she had asked him. He let himself have that much. A few months earlier, he had been a stranger who knew her name without having spoken to her. Now she could ask for his company without feeling obliged to explain the request.

He smiled, noticed himself smiling, and made an unsuccessful attempt to stop.

I'll be there.

He considered adding something humorous, but nothing occurred to him that would improve the sentence. For once, he sent a perfectly adequate answer without interfering with it. She had asked a friend to attend; the friend had agreed. He placed the phone aside.

A minute later, he opened the conversation again. He was not waiting for another message. He wanted to see the one already there. This struck him as a particularly foolish use of modern technology, but the objection did not stop him.

He imagined explaining it to her. You see, Sanondita, I understood that you wanted company. Unfortunately, I have since spent an unreasonable amount of time being pleased that the company happened to be mine.

She would probably laugh. The thought pleased him almost as much as the message.

Then another question arrived: Would you have asked anyone?

He held the phone without typing. Of course she might have. There was no reason she should spend a lonely afternoon merely because he could not attend. He knew that; he still wanted to have been her first thought. Admitting the wish embarrassed him more than reading the message for the third time.

He turned the phone face down. Tomorrow they would attend their lessons. They might talk. One of them might say something foolish, and the other would laugh. He had looked forward to less with considerably greater difficulty.

The next day, Sanondita was already in the classroom when he arrived. She greeted him as usual, and he greeted her. He had spent part of the evening imagining what it would feel like to arrive knowing she wanted him there. In practice, he put down his bag, sat beside her, and began talking about the day.

It was reassuringly simple. Nobody else had known there was a private drama to conclude.

When class began, he copied what he could from the board, occasionally falling behind and recovering with handwriting that would require considerable interpretation later. Sanondita worked beside him. At one point she turned to share a quiet observation. He answered, and she lowered her eyes, trying not to laugh. He faced the board with such deliberate seriousness that her shoulders began to move again.

The teacher continued. Utkarsh held his pen above the unfinished sentence in his notebook. He had once wanted so badly to speak to her; now she turned towards him because she had something to say. He had once wondered whether she would remember his name. Now she could ask him to come tomorrow.

If only you knew how little it takes.

For a moment, he wished she could know without his having to say anything, without the knowledge changing the way she sat beside him. Then she went back to writing, and he looked at the board. The line he needed had already disappeared. He had missed part of the explanation while being pleased to have someone with whom to discuss it.

He reconstructed what he could and made a respectable effort to listen. They spoke occasionally through the rest of the lesson, neither saying anything that would have interested the room around them. When it ended, they gathered their things and continued with the day.

He did not ask whether she would have invited someone else. He wanted to keep the ease with which she had asked him. And somewhere beneath that contentment was a wish he could not quite put away: that on some future morning she might enter, notice the empty chair, and wonder when he would arrive.

Sitting in the front row continued to require an appearance of reasonable dedication. They generally managed it. They listened, took notes, and answered questions when required. Their

difficulties arose when the teacher turned towards the board or paused to consult his notes, leaving a few dangerous seconds in which one of them might notice something.

Sometimes a whisper was enough. At other times, speaking was too risky. One afternoon, Sanondita moved her notebook towards Utkarsh. Beneath the lesson, in a small clear line, she had written:

Sir has said "one last point" three times.

Utkarsh looked up. The teacher was consulting his notes with the air of a man who had plenty left to say. Sanondita pressed her lips together. Looking at her had been a mistake.

He bent over the notebook and wrote:

The last point has relatives.

The reply took longer than it deserved. He was trying to make it funny while employing a handwriting style that regarded legibility as an optional accomplishment. He pushed the notebook back.

Sanondita examined the sentence. Her expression changed. She leaned closer, looked at him with disbelief, and placed her pen beneath the final word. He pointed at it, as though its identity could be established by indicating where it lived. She looked again. This did not help.

He took the notebook back and rewrote "relatives" carefully. The second version was marginally more successful. Sanondita read it, glanced towards the teacher, and lowered her head. Her shoulders began to shake.

Utkarsh faced the board. There was nothing amusing about the board. This proved insufficient. The teacher had reached a part of the explanation with which he seemed particularly satisfied; his expression made it impossible to recover. Utkarsh looked down again. Beside him, Sanondita was pressing her lips together so firmly that he could see the effort it cost her.

For several seconds, neither dared look at the other. The lesson continued around their silence. He tried to begin copying, produced half a word, and waited until his hand was steady enough to finish it.

Eventually, they resumed their notes. Sanondita left the original sentence visible beside his correction. He wondered whether she would be able to read it later. He rather hoped she would still need him for one word. It was pleasing to imagine a joke that required them both to be present in order to make sense.

The exchanges became an occasional habit. When a remark could not be spoken, one of them wrote a few words and moved the notebook across. This protected the lesson from interruption, though it did very little to protect them from the consequences of finding each other amusing.

Sometimes she read his contribution and turned towards him with exaggerated disapproval. He would attempt to defend it with a look. Her smile usually arrived before either could pretend the conversation was over.

He liked being ridiculous with her. In July, a poorly chosen sentence could occupy him for an entire evening. Now he could make a bad joke, receive a look of disbelief, and try again another day. She did not make him feel that one foolish remark had used up his right to speak.

It was during a General Awareness class that he paid proper attention to her handwriting. Their notebooks had crossed between them often enough, but that afternoon he found himself watching a line form beneath her pen.

Some letters were rounded, others narrower, a few leaning towards the next. Each seemed to arrive where it belonged. The spaces between words remained almost impossibly consistent. Even when she hurried, her lines retained an order his notebook had never displayed, not even in the brief period immediately after its purchase.

He looked at his own page. It resembled the surviving evidence of a disagreement between a pen and its owner. Some words were recognisable; others appeared to belong to a language he had intended to learn and abandoned halfway through.

Beside him, she reached the end of one line and began another without hesitation. He wondered whether her thoughts moved like that, whether she knew where a sentence should end before she spoke. Perhaps even the things she chose not to say were arranged somewhere with the same quiet care.

Then he remembered that she was copying from the board. The sentences belonged to the teacher, whose explanation had already wandered through several unnecessary qualifications. Utkarsh ought to have abandoned the theory immediately. Instead, he considered whether the act of copying might still reveal something.

His own handwriting, he hoped, did not provide an accurate account of his intelligence.

He looked back at the board. The teacher had moved on. Once again, a line lay unfinished beneath his pen. He reconstructed something resembling a sentence; whether it bore any relationship to the lesson was less certain.

He had wanted to know her better. Apparently even the way she wrote a word could now detain him. He imagined telling her this and knew she would have reasonable questions about how he spent his time. Smiling to himself, he returned to his notes.

Around this period, another small habit appeared. Sometimes Sanondita took the clip from her hair and attached it to his shirt.

The first time, he noticed the movement before he had decided how to react. She did it with easy familiarity and returned to whatever she had been doing. He looked down. A hair clip. On his shirt. Until recently, he had regarded these as objects with which he had very little involvement. One had now acquired a position on his clothing.

He considered asking why, then imagined making her explain that she had wanted to put it somewhere. His shirt was available. The arrangement seemed satisfactory to everyone except the person attempting to understand it.

He faced the board. For a while, he was unusually careful when he moved. He adjusted his notebook, checked that the clip had not shifted, and wondered whether this additional care was visible.

It’s a hair clip, he told himself. Then why are you sitting like that?

He relaxed his shoulders. A moment later, he checked it again and almost laughed. Sanondita was writing. She appeared to have forgotten the object whose safety had become his principal concern.

He liked that she had placed it there without pausing to consider him. After all his care over where to sit and how much room to leave, she had reached across as easily as she reached for her notebook. He could hear the teacher. He could follow the explanation if he tried. He sat a little more comfortably and let the clip remain.

Later she took it back. The lesson continued, and he did not mention it afterward. On his way home, however, he remembered the ridiculous care with which he had guarded it, along with her laughter over his writing and the movement of her pen. He could recall those things more readily than what had been taught.

He wondered whether anything from the afternoon had stayed with her. The question was becoming familiar. He did not need her to remember the clip; he could hardly account for remembering it himself. He only hoped there were moments she kept because he had been part of them.

The next time she leaned towards him with a remark she could not say aloud, he moved his notebook closer, ready for whatever she wished to write.

By the last week of August, Utkarsh had begun to suspect that courage sometimes consisted of asking an ordinary question without first rehearsing seventeen possible consequences. He could sit beside Sanondita, exchange jokes, and leave the classroom without committing a memorable act of stupidity. There were even occasions when he forgot to be nervous. These were his happiest moments, and afterward the ones he found most difficult to believe.

Yet coaching still determined when they met. Their messages continued the conversations begun there; their walks home ended where their routes separated. He had begun to wonder what even half an hour together somewhere else would be like. He had no particular destination in mind. He wanted to discover whether a conversation could continue without a lesson waiting to interrupt it.

He could simply ask her to go somewhere. The possibility presented itself occasionally and was dismissed with admirable speed. Go where? To do what? He had answers to neither question, except the one answer he could not comfortably give: he wanted a little more time with her.

He did not think she would be offended. Their friendship had become easy enough that an invitation might seem entirely natural to her. But he could already hear himself making it too elaborate, supplying assurances nobody had requested, until the simplest proposal sounded difficult to refuse.

There had been an earlier outing with their friends that she had not attended. He knew she had her own plans. Nevertheless, he had learned something from the experience: an invitation could be refused. This was hardly a discovery, merely a familiar fact made considerably less pleasant by its application to one particular person.

Then Raksha Bandhan approached, and a practical problem presented itself. He needed to buy a gift for his sister. Or rather, he decided he needed to buy her a gift. The distinction deserved some examination.

He had not made a habit of personally selecting clothes for her. His previous contributions had required less thought, and sometimes no shopping at all. Now he felt that a carefully chosen present would be a fine expression of brotherly affection. It was an admirable development in his character. The timing was unfortunate.

So this is what you've become, he thought. You discover your responsibilities towards your sister because you want an afternoon with another girl.

The accusation was not entirely fair. He intended to buy the gift. His sister would receive something, and he hoped she would like it. Surely a good deed retained some value when its author had additional motives.

Then why haven't you bought her clothes before?

He found the question unnecessarily hostile.

There was a genuine difficulty. He knew almost nothing about choosing women's clothing. He could distinguish a shirt from a dress, and understood, in a broad theoretical sense, that garments came in different sizes. Beyond that, his expertise diminished rapidly. Sanondita might know what to look for.

He had found his reason. It was useful and almost suspiciously convenient.

The evening before Raksha Bandhan, he opened their WhatsApp conversation and wrote that he needed a small favour. He sent it before he could improve it into something incomprehensible. Sanondita asked what the favour was.

Precisely the question a reasonable person would ask. Somehow, he had not prepared an answer he was willing to send.

He could explain everything there: a gift for his sister, some help choosing it after class. But he wanted to ask in person. He told himself he would be better able to judge whether it inconvenienced her, whether she hesitated, whether she was willing. Beneath those considerations was a simpler wish. If she agreed, he wanted to be there when she said it.

He told her to come to coaching the next day; he would explain there.

It was an absurd amount of secrecy for the purchase of a garment. His sister, had she known the arrangements being made in the name of her gift, might reasonably have demanded something considerably more expensive.

He put the phone away. Tomorrow he would have to ask, and then let her answer. There was nothing more he could accomplish tonight by inventing different ways for the conversation to go. He attempted this for a while anyway, then wondered why he had not simply bought a box of sweets.

The next day, the classroom looked exactly as it always did. This seemed almost discourteous. Students were finding seats, notebooks opening, familiar voices crossing the room. Someone was asking about a previous lesson. Someone else had arrived without the material for the present one and was negotiating access to a neighbour's notes.

Sanondita was there. They greeted each other, but before he found an opening, the lesson began. The favour remained unexplained between them while the teacher spoke. Utkarsh listened, took notes, and occasionally glanced at the clock. He had never found forty minutes so personally objectionable.

When the first class ended, the room loosened into conversation. Students stood, stretched, checked their phones, and considered whether the next session justified remaining in the building. Utkarsh turned towards Sanondita. She remembered his message and asked about the small favour.

He had imagined the opening so often that, when it arrived, he briefly lost the ability to use it. Then he mentioned Raksha Bandhan. He wanted to buy his sister something to wear, he explained, but was not particularly good at choosing such things. This admission required no courage; it was an established fact.

Would she help him select something?

Neither of them was planning to attend the second class. There was a shopping complex nearby. It would not take long. He tried to make the proposal sound practical, almost incidental. It would not take long: he had never spoken a sentence with less desire for it to be true.

Sanondita considered the suggestion. Utkarsh waited, suddenly aware of the notebook he was still holding open. He could tell her it

was all right if she had somewhere to be. He could say he would manage alone. He had almost begun to withdraw the invitation on her behalf when she agreed.

For a moment, he did not know what to do with the answer. He had prepared for hesitation, refusal, even the remarks with which he would demonstrate that he minded neither. He had devoted remarkably little attention to success.

He asked whether she was sure. She was. He closed his notebook and nodded, attempting the composure of a man whose shopping arrangements had proceeded exactly as expected.

Of course she's coming. You asked for help. She said yes. This is how requests work.

The argument was sound. It did little to account for the difficulty he was having with the zip of his bag.

There remained the question of where to go. For a brief, disgraceful moment, he considered somewhere farther away, a place requiring a longer walk or a journey through the city. More time: that was the entire attraction. He could make it sound practical, but she had agreed to help with a purchase. He looked at her and suggested the shopping complex attached to the coaching centre.

They would not have to travel, and she could leave when the shopping was done. He still wished they had farther to go. He finished packing his bag without proposing a longer route.

As they left, he remembered the earlier outing she had missed. There had been a whole group then. Today there were only the two of them. The circumstances were different, and he knew better than to make an answer out of the comparison. Still, he glanced at her with a thought he could not quite prevent.

You came.

She was speaking about something ordinary. He answered, and they continued towards the shops. In his rehearsals, he had worried about uncomfortable silences and the effort of not looking too pleased. Now she said something that made him laugh, and his

reply made her laugh too. He had imagined the afternoon often enough to be embarrassed by how little his imagination had prepared him for its ease.

People moved past them. The shops were ahead. He felt a sudden affection for this indifferent stretch of the day and wanted to tell someone what had happened: he had asked, and she had said yes. But explaining why it mattered would require explaining the months before it. He kept the pleasure to himself and listened to her.

At the entrance, Sanondita looked towards the shops, considering where to begin. Utkarsh followed her inside. For the next little while, they had somewhere to go together. He did not need to find a reason to remain beside her.

The first difficulty arose almost immediately. He had brought Sanondita to help choose a gift but neglected to consider what, precisely, his sister might like. He could recognise her voice from another room and predict which of his habits would annoy her. Her preferences in clothing belonged to a branch of knowledge he had never seriously attempted to acquire.

Sanondita asked what he was looking for.

“Something nice,” he said.

She looked at him. He recognised the inadequacy of the answer.

“For my sister.”

“Yes, I know.”

“A top, maybe.”

“What kind?”

He considered this. “The kind she’ll like.”

Sanondita laughed. “You’ve thought this through.”

“Very carefully.”

“I can tell.”

They began looking. It was unexpectedly pleasant to follow her through the shops. In class, there had always been a timetable, a teacher waiting to resume, another subject about to begin. Here she

could stop to examine something, change her mind, move on. He could ask a question without first checking whether somebody was about to ask the entire room a more important one.

She took the task seriously, studying colours, comparing designs, checking sizes. Occasionally she held up a garment for his opinion. Utkarsh offered it whenever asked. It was usually useless.

"This one?"

"It's nice."

"And that one?"

"Also nice."

She lowered the second top. "Do you think everything is nice?"

"No."

"Then which one isn't?"

He looked around. There were several dozen garments within sight; he had already committed himself to approving most of them.

"That one," he said, indicating something at a safe distance.

"What's wrong with it?"

He examined it more carefully. "Nothing, actually."

She began laughing again, and he laughed with her. In class, they would already have lowered their heads and pretended to be studying. Here she could let the laugh finish. He did not have to look away to help her stop. He watched her turn back to the clothes, still smiling, and hoped she would find another reason before they left.

At one point, she handed him her purse. He took it without thinking. A moment later came her phone, then her handkerchief. She continued browsing while he stood beside a display with several of her possessions in his hands, like an assistant whose employment had begun without the formality of an interview.

He adjusted his grip. Her phone rested securely against the purse; the handkerchief was in danger of slipping, and he caught it between his fingers.

Guardian of the handkerchief, he thought. A respectable appointment. The salary was poor, but the responsibilities were considerable.

She asked him to look at another top, and he moved closer. He kept the phone turned in against the purse. He had spent months worrying about making her uncomfortable; now she was comparing clothes, certain he would keep her things safe. He liked being useful to her in a way so small she had not needed to stop and ask.

“Are you going to help me choose, or just stand there?”

“I’m helping.”

“How?”

“I’m holding everything.”

She looked at his hands. “That is true.”

He accepted the concession graciously. They moved to another section.

Eventually, Sanondita found a top she thought would suit his sister. She held it up, considered it from a different angle, and asked his opinion. This time he looked properly. The colour was good. He could imagine his sister wearing it, although his imagination was not particularly well informed.

“Yes,” he said. “I think this one.”

Sanondita seemed satisfied. At last, an opinion had survived examination. Then he looked at the other garments nearby, and back at the top. Something appeared to be missing.

She noticed his hesitation. “What?”

“Nothing.”

“What happened?”

He considered whether the question would expose an unacceptable degree of ignorance. There were limits to what a man could reasonably be expected to know. He proceeded.

“Where’s the bottom?”

“The what?”

“The bottom. The matching one.”

For a moment, she seemed not to understand. Then she did, and laughed so suddenly that he found himself smiling before he knew what was funny.

"What?"

She tried to answer and could not. He looked at the top again.

"I'm asking seriously."

That made matters worse. She turned slightly away, laughing harder, while he waited with the patience of a man whose legitimate enquiry had caused a minor public disturbance.

When she could speak, she explained that the top was sold separately. It did not require a matching bottom. His sister could wear it with something she already owned. He listened and considered the information.

"So you buy only half?"

"Utkarsh!"

"What? I'm trying to understand."

She laughed again. He joined her, though he continued to believe his question had possessed considerable merit. Surely there had been a time when a person could purchase an outfit without separate negotiations for its upper and lower portions. He did not offer this historical theory aloud. Sanondita had already suffered enough.

When the laughter subsided, she explained once more, and he accepted her judgment. She took back her belongings, and they bought the top. It was a respectable gift, chosen with care and paid for without incident. His sister would receive something he hoped she would like. He had fulfilled the obligation he had discovered rather late.

As they left the shop, he became aware that the purpose of the outing was complete. There were no more colours to compare, no further questions about sizes. Even the missing bottom had been accounted for. He looked at the shopping bag. A few minutes earlier, he had been grateful to find the right gift. Now he wished the selection had proved more difficult.

They walked through the complex, talking about the purchase and laughing occasionally at his expense. He defended himself where possible, although his arguments were growing weaker. He was not particularly concerned about winning. An argument could be enjoyable when the other person laughed in the right places.

Outside, the late-August air was warm and heavy. Vehicles moved along the road; pedestrians made their way past one another; shopfronts reflected the restless movement of the city. Nothing had changed while they were inside. Utkarsh found this faintly unreasonable. He had spent an afternoon with Sanondita somewhere other than coaching or the road home. He had made her laugh so hard she could not answer him. Surely the city might have had the courtesy to look a little different.

But the road was the same, and Sanondita was speaking beside him. He turned towards her. For a while they walked without urgency. Then he began to notice how little distance remained before their paths would separate.

He was leaving Kolkata for his hometown and would be away for three or four days. He had known this before asking her to come shopping. The length of the visit had seemed perfectly reasonable then.

Three or four days. He had gone longer without speaking to her. There had been weeks in March and April when he had not exchanged a single word with her and the world had functioned efficiently enough. Now he found himself counting the classes he would miss, imagining her taking her seat while he was somewhere else. She might have something to say, or notice something funny, and he would not be the person near enough to hear it.

He could message her. Of course he could. But he had begun to like being there before she decided to speak.

The bag moved against his leg as they walked. He considered telling her he had enjoyed the afternoon. It was a simple thing to say. He had spent enough of it laughing that the admission would hardly surprise her.

He thanked her and told her it had been fun. She seemed pleased, and they exchanged a few more words about the gift. He hoped his sister would like it; he hoped Sanondita had enjoyed choosing it. Neither hope seemed difficult to express in the ordinary conversation they were having.

Everything remained easy. That was what made the end difficult. There was no awkwardness to resolve, no unfinished task that required another minute. They had bought the gift. She had to go.

Their goodbye was ordinary. Neither lingered over it. There were no promises, no carefully chosen words. She turned away, and Utkarsh began to turn in the opposite direction.

Then he stopped and looked back.

For a few moments, he could distinguish her easily. Other people moved between them, and he began to catch only glimpses as she continued along the pavement. He remained where he was, the shopping bag in his hand.

He could call her name. Sanondita. He could almost hear her answering, almost see the questioning look with which she would turn. What is it?

What would he say? That he had enjoyed the afternoon? He had told her. That he was leaving for a few days? She knew. He could say he wished they had spent longer together. Friends said such things. Yet he imagined her waiting for him to finish, and knew he would have difficulty leaving the sentence there.

Do you know what you've done to me today?

He disliked the question as soon as it formed. She had helped him choose a gift and laughed at a foolish enquiry. That was all she had done. The rest had happened quietly beside her while she went about the afternoon.

He shifted the bag to his other hand. Would you miss me? That was closer to what he meant. She might notice he was absent, might message him or simply continue with her plans. He would not stay silent to find out. He knew how unpleasant it was to wait for a message without understanding the silence on the other side.

Still, he wanted to know whether an afternoon felt different to her when he was not there. Whether she ever turned to tell him something before remembering the chair was empty. He had become so accustomed to making a place for her in his day that he wished, sometimes, to stumble upon evidence of a place in hers.

Inside the bag was his sister's top. He looked at it and nearly laughed. He had spent a considerable part of the outing demonstrating his ignorance, been entrusted with a handkerchief, and briefly mistaken a complete purchase for half of one. Now he stood in Kolkata with the expression of a man who had misplaced something important.

Nothing was missing. She had come, she had been comfortable with him, and they had laughed together. The afternoon had gone as well as he could have hoped. He wanted one more minute before it became an afternoon he could only remember.

He looked up. She was farther away.

Turn around.

Then, immediately: No. Don't.

If she turned, he would have to wave. She might wonder why he was still there. Worse, she might smile, and he would have to begin the business of leaving all over again.

Go on, he thought. Get home. And take care.

He had not said the words aloud. She knew the way; she had been getting home long before he had known her name. Nevertheless, he wished he had said them while she was close enough to hear. Now there was no reason to call across the pavement simply to add what he could have put into the goodbye.

He hoped she would remember the missing bottom and laugh once more. Perhaps she would tell someone about his question. He imagined being ridiculous in a story she chose to tell, and the thought brought a small smile. He would accept that version of himself quite happily if the afternoon had been worth carrying home.

A group of pedestrians passed between them. He lost sight of her, waited, and saw her again farther down the pavement. The small relief embarrassed him. Nothing had happened; she had simply continued walking. Soon another group, another turn, would take her out of sight altogether.

Around him, people talked, checked phones, argued with drivers, and carried purchases home. The afternoon was becoming evening. He could still hear her saying his name in the shop, half reproach and half laughter. Utkarsh. He had spent so long hoping she would remember it. Today she had said it because he was being an idiot, and he would remember the sound with unreasonable pleasure.

He thought of calling once more, only to hear her answer. He did not. For a little while, he could still make her out among the people ahead. Then he could not.

He remained facing the direction she had gone. He had known from the beginning that they would part. He had simply not expected the afternoon to end so soon after he had stopped wondering what to say.

The bag rested against his leg. He looked down, adjusted his grip, and started towards home. After several steps he glanced back. He could no longer see her. He turned forward again.

There was no one beside him now, no one waiting for an answer or trying not to laugh. The words came easily where she could not hear them.

I hope you get home safely, Sanondita.

He walked on.

I hope you liked today.

Another few steps.

I did.

He almost smiled.

More than I can tell you.

The crowd carried him in the opposite direction. He did not look back again.